> foot-lights in the glamorous role as a valiant gladiator over the emotionally-combustible Kashmir question.[4]

On 10 January 1962, Menon had issued a statement at Tezpur in Assam —a frontline position during the war that broke out nine months later— saying that 'the India-China border dispute was not of such a magnitude as could precipitate a war.'[5] In a sense, he was right. China would not go to war over the actual border dispute, but he failed to grasp the broader geopolitical and ideological context in which China decided to 'settle accounts with the Indians'.[6]

Menon was one of the most controversial, some would argue, divisive, figures in Nehru's cabinet. He was one of Nehru's oldest friends and closest political confidantes whose interests and actions were not always appreciated by the army. In 1959, the legendary General Kodendera Subayya Thimayya even resigned his post as the Chief of Army Staff over disagreements with Menon. Nehru, however, refused to accept Thimayya's resignation and persuaded him to stay on, which he did until his retirement in 1961.

A British observer even went as far as saying that Menon 'is felt to be one of the Nehru family (in a way no other Minister is or has been) … indeed Nehru behaved towards Menon in a manner so paternal to suggest that he saw in Menon the son he had always so much wanted to have'.[7] Other Westerners portrayed Menon as 'India's Rasputin', 'the Hindu Vishinsky', and 'India's Communist-cuddling roving ambassador'.[8]

Menon's anti-Western stance became an issue when India, during the height of the fighting in the Himalayas, saw it had no alternative but to turn to the United States for support. On 23 October, three days before Nehru made the official request for American support, the US ambassador in New Delhi, John K. Galbraith, informed India's Foreign Secretary M.J. Desai that Menon's retention of the post as defence minister represented one of the 'more serious problems' standing in the way of American military aid to India.[9] Hence, he had to go. After a brief interlude with Nehru in charge of the defence ministry, Yashwantrao Balwantrao Chavan, who had played a prominent role during India's freedom struggle, became the new minister.

Despite the close friendship between Nehru and Menon, it is also clear that there were serious disagreements between the two. Nehru was perhaps more sceptical of the Chinese than he was prepared to show. As early as